

Clemson - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-25-caliber defensive baseline with ACC-title upside, but a much wider floor than the talent brand suggests because quarterback remains unresolved and the roster replaces an extraordinary NFL-bound class.
Preseason consensus	AP Others receiving votes (112 points) · Conference poll ACC No. 4 (2,520 points; 7 first-place votes) · SP+ No. 23
Returning production	55% (No. 58) overall · Off. 48% (No. 88) · Def. 61% (No. 33)
Primer power rating	+13.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.9 wins · most likely 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar - Similar-to-slightly higher underlying ceiling than the 7-6 result, but with substantially more personnel volatility and no settled quarterback.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Clemson leans on DC Tom Allen's 4-2-5 and stars LB Sammy Brown, DE Will Heldt and CB Ashton Hampton while OC Chad Morris builds a run-led, play-action offense around WR T.J. Moore and WR Bryant Wesco Jr. The QB battle and rebuilt lines drive the variance.

Bottom line: Clemson has top-25 defensive and receiving talent, but unresolved QB play and major two-line attrition make this a high-variance ACC contender.

Beats expectations if: One QB separates, OC Chad Morris gets efficient play-action from the RB/WR talent, four settled OL spots hold up, and the rebuilt defense preserves its havoc edge.

Disappoints if: QB uncertainty and inconsistent protection persist while the rebuilt DT/secondary groups cannot replace the NFL losses fast enough.

Five things to remember

- 1 **? QB question:** QB Christopher Vizzina and true freshman QB Tait Reynolds remained in a live starting-quarterback competition through Aug. 23; no winner can be declared.
- 2 **NFL Draft losses:** Nine members of the 2025 Clemson roster were selected in the 2026 NFL Draft, including QB Cade Klubnik and major starters across both lines and the secondary.
- 3 **★ WR T.J. Moore / Bryant Wesco Jr.:** WR T.J. Moore and Bryant Wesco Jr. give the new quarterback a high-end receiving core; Wesco is a current healthy 2026 return despite the spring-guide lost-starter anomaly.
- 4 **★ Defensive stars:** LB Sammy Brown, DE Will Heldt and CB Ashton Hampton are the defense's recognized returning stars, but the interior line and much of the secondary have been rebuilt around transfers.
- 5 **? Front / OL availability:** DT Kourtney Kelly is out for the season, Vic Burley's opener status is not settled, and the fifth/right-guard OL spot remained open late in camp.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	7-6 (4-4 ACC)	● Average / bowl-level
Scoring	27.2 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	392.2 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	124.5 YPG · 3.9 YPC	● Below average
Pass efficiency	7.33 YPA · 22 TD / 7 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	34.3%	● Poor
Scoring defense	20.5 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	356.7 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	105.5 YPG · 3.5 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	251.2 YPG · 6.75 YPA · 18 TD allowed	● Good / above average

Clemson’s 2025 offense was ordinary, especially on the ground and on third down.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+2.59 · No. 48	● Good / above average
Off. EPA/play	+0.019 · No. 60	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	43.3% · No. 58	● Average / mixed
Off. explosive-play rate	11.9% · No. 70	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	14.7% · No. 59	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	+4.09 · No. 28	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.044 · No. 45	● Good / above average
Def. success rate allowed	38.0% · No. 28	● Very good
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	10.8% · No. 42	● Good / above average
Havoc created	19.5% · No. 9	● Elite

Advanced-stat read: The defense was legitimately strong, including No. 9 havoc creation, while the offense was mostly average. Clemson needs the new QB/OC pairing to lift the offense without sacrificing that disruption.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Dabo Swinney - returning in same role	● ↔ Dabo Swinney's return keeps the program structure stable through the coordinator transition.
OC / offensive play-caller	◆ Chad Morris - new external hire; from Texas State Passing Game Coordinator/Wide Receivers Coach	● ↔ Transition adds uncertainty; caller established
DC / LB	Tom Allen - returning in same role	● ↔ Tom Allen's return preserves defensive system continuity while the offense changes coordinators.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ RB Chris Johnson Jr.	SMU	● ↔ Major piece of the planned multi-back rotation.
Out	To	Loss
QB Cade Klubnik	NFL (N.Y. Jets), Round 4, No. 110	● ↓ Drafted starter leaves the season-defining QB vacancy.
RB Adam Randall	NFL (Baltimore), Round 5, No. 174	● ↓ Another drafted starter leaves larger roles for the new RB rotation.
WR Antonio Williams	NFL (Washington), Round 3, No. 71	● ↓ Starting receiver leaves WR T.J. Moore/WR Bryant Wesco Jr. as the anchors.
OL Blake Miller	NFL (Detroit), Round 1, No. 17	● ↓ Every-game starter departs in a broad OL reset.
OL Tristan Leigh	NFL (Minnesota), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Ten-game starter adds to the OL rebuild.

Offensive net: ● ↓ Clear drop in proven continuity, especially at quarterback and offensive line, with enough returning receiver talent to preserve upside if the new backfield/QB structure works.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ CB Elliot Washington II	Penn State	● ↔ Projected starter opposite CB Ashton Hampton.
♦ S Jerome Carter III	Old Dominion	● ↔ Expected starting safety.
♦ S Corey Myrick	Southern Miss	● ↔ Likely starter in the rebuilt back end.
♦ DT Markus Strong	Oklahoma	● ↔ Primary rotation candidate in a rebuilt DT room.
Out	To	Loss
DT Peter Woods	NFL (Kansas City), Round 1, No. 29	● ↓ Foundational interior starter departs.
DE T.J. Parker	NFL (Buffalo), Round 2, No. 35	● ↓ Starting edge removes proven pass-rush volume.
CB Avieon Terrell	NFL (Atlanta), Round 2, No. 48	● ↓ Another starting corner adds to secondary turnover.
LB Wade Woodaz	NFL (Houston), Round 4, No. 123	● ↓ An additional starting LB leaves LB Sammy Brown as the centerpiece.
DT DeMonte Capehart	NFL (Tampa Bay), Round 5, No. 155	● ↓ Major DT departure deepens the interior reset.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Large decline in proven continuity despite strong returning stars and a substantial transfer response; the ceiling remains good, but the front/secondary are much less settled.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Run-led two-back attack with play action, tempo and selective deep shots.	WR T.J. Moore/WR Bryant Wesco Jr., multiple backs and four settled OL spots.	Unsettled QB and pass protection after an average 2025 offense.
Defense	DC Tom Allen’s 4-2-5 around LB Sammy Brown, DE Will Heldt and CB Ashton Hampton.	Top-30 adjusted/success-rate defense and No. 9 havoc creation.	Rebuilt DT/secondary groups plus DT Kourtney Kelly’s season-ending loss.
Special teams	Stable kicking with a long-snapper transition.	K Nolan Hauser is established and Lou Groza-recognized.	SP+ ranks the unit No. 41 and LS Philip Florenzo departs.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↓	Low	QB Christopher Vizzina/QB Tait Reynolds remain live contenders replacing QB Cade Klubnik.
RB	● B-	● ↓	Medium	RB Gideon Davidson/RB Chris Johnson Jr. replace a drafted 13-game starter.
WR	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	WR T.J. Moore and WR Bryant Wesco Jr. give Clemson two high-end returners.
TE	● B-	● ↓	Medium-high	Olsen Patt-Henry returns as an established starter, while TE Josh Sapp transfers after 267 snaps/11 catches.
OL	● B-	● ↓	Medium	Four spots are settled, but RG and pass protection remain concerns after veteran losses.
DL/Edge	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	DE Will Heldt returns, but the DT room is rebuilt and DT Kourtney Kelly is out.
LB	● A-	● ↓	Medium-high	LB Sammy Brown is a national preseason star and established starter, though drafted LB Wade Woodaz removes a proven 12-game partner.
Secondary	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	CB Ashton Hampton anchors a back end replacing multiple starters with transfers.
Special teams	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	Hauser is established and Lou Groza-recognized, but SP+ ranks the full unit No. 41 and the long snapper changes.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	Dabo, Allen, Luke and Eason return; Morris is a new external OC but his 2026 offensive play-calling is settled.
Overall	● B+	● ↔	Medium-low	Top-25 baseline with substantial QB and two-sided turnover risk.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
★ Sammy Brown	LB	● National star / centerpiece defender	AP 2nd team · Walter Camp 1st team · ACC 1st team · Bednarik · Nagurski · Butkus · Walter Camp POY	The most decorated returning player and the anchor expected to preserve Clemson's defense-first identity.
Ashton Hampton	CB	● High-end conference star	ACC 1st team · Bednarik · Thorpe	The primary proven secondary anchor amid major transfer/NFL turnover around him.
Bryant Wesco Jr.	WR	● High-end conference starter	ACC 1st team	Healthy early in camp after a 2025 season-ending injury and central to giving the new quarterback a high-ceiling outside target.
T.J. Moore	WR	● High-end Power Four starter	Biletnikoff	Returning starting receiver and the other half of Clemson's strongest offensive position group.
Will Heldt	DE	● High-end conference starter	ACC 1st team	The proven edge anchor in a front replacing multiple NFL/transfer departures.
Christopher Vizzina	QB	● Starting-QB contender / current pole position	-	One of two live contenders; Clemson's ceiling changes materially if he wins the job and proves he can replace Klubnik efficiently.
◆ Tait Reynolds	QB	● High-upside true-freshman starter contender	-	Remained in the live competition through Aug. 23; his presence is why no settled QB assumption is permissible.
Gideon Davidson	RB	● Lead-back candidate	-	Opened camp with first-team work and is first in line to replace RB Adam Randall's starting role.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Moderate overall by national standards, but the first five games contain two top-10 SP+ opponents and a cross-country road trip before Clemson gets its only bye.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 41
Hardest stretch	at LSU → Georgia Southern → North Carolina → at California → Miami
Swing games	Virginia Tech, at Florida State, at Duke, South Carolina
Advantage	The bye comes immediately after Miami and before Charleston Southern, creating a reset before the seven-game closing run; Clemson also gets Virginia Tech, Georgia Tech and South Carolina at home.
Expected	7.9 wins · most likely 8-4
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Clemson's brand and defensive star power may pull prices toward a restored-contender narrative, while AP voting and the unresolved QB justify more caution. The attractive zone is a top-25 defensive team price, not a fully repaired national-power price.
Back them when	When the price reflects quarterback uncertainty and the matchup lets Clemson lean on its defense, run game and Moore/Wesco play-action shots rather than requiring an unproven QB to win a high-volume dropback game.
Fade/pass when	Against opponents that can stress the rebuilt DT/secondary groups or force long passing-down sequences before the fifth OL spot and QB hierarchy are settled; with Medium-low evaluation confidence, demand a meaningful price edge.
Key monitor	QB winner and snap plan, fifth/right-guard OL spot, Vic Burley opener availability and DT rotation, transfer-secondary snap distribution, T.J. Moore/Jay Haynes health only if current status worsens
Week 1 baseline	Clemson +9.5 at LSU · rating-only baseline; Clemson primer +13.0 minus LSU primer +20.5 minus 2.0 default road/home-field adjustment; no matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Clemson +10.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Clemson's defense still has legitimate star power in LB Sammy Brown, DE Will Heldt and CB Ashton Hampton, while WR T.J. Moore and WR Bryant Wesco Jr. give the new quarterback real help. The unresolved QB job and rebuilt OL keep the offense's floor uncertain.

The defense also replaces exceptional NFL talent in the front and secondary, so last year's havoc cannot simply be assumed. **7.9 wins and 8-4** fits a talented ACC contender that should be priced as top-25 caliber, not as a fully restored national power.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [camp update](#) · [roster roles](#) · [coaching](#) · [departures](#) · [2025 context](#) · [current update](#)

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